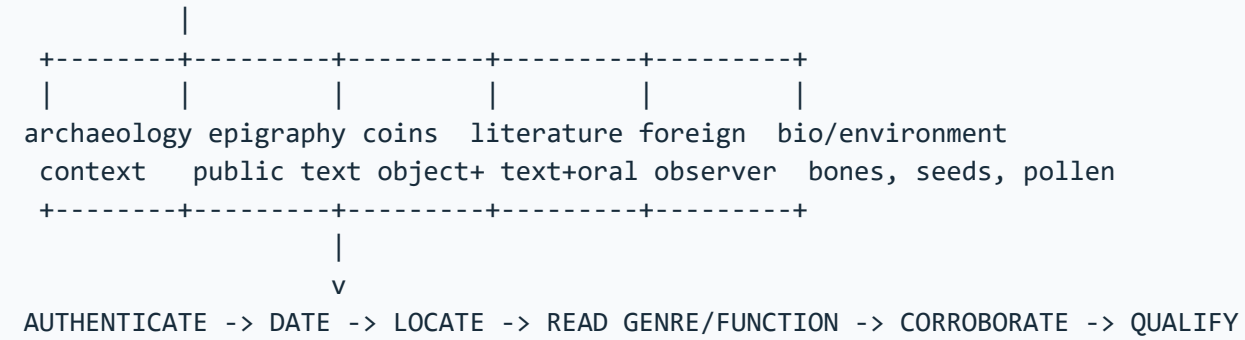


ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/12: The source universe: trace to reconstruction

SOURCES OF ANCIENT INDIA



ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/12: Archaeology: context before object

SURVEY -> SITE -> GRID/TRENCH -> STRATIGRAPHY -> ASSEMBLAGE -> INTERPRETATION

|

v

Law of superposition: an undisturbed lower layer is relatively earlier.

Artefact alone: weak provenance | artefact in sealed context: stronger association

Industry = recurrent technique/tool set; culture = patterned material assemblage.

Intrusion, redeposition and mixed layers can break a simple sequence.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/12: Dating ladder: precision with error bars

RELATIVE DATE	ABSOLUTE/CHRONOMETRIC DATE
stratigraphy -> seriation -> typology	radiocarbon -> calibrated range
cross-dating -> association	TL/OSL -> last heating or light exposure
	dendrochronology where wood survives
+-----+-----+	
v	

A date belongs to a sample and context, not automatically to an entire culture.
Report range, calibration and contamination risk; probability is not certainty.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/12: Inscriptions: public text under source criticism

MATERIAL + SCRIPT + LANGUAGE + FORMULA + FIND-SPOT

|

v

DECIPHER -> DATE -> TRANSLATE -> IDENTIFY ISSUER/AUDIENCE -> HISTORICAL USE

|

+-----+-----+

|

titles, grants, donors

|

failure, dissent and routine life omitted

|

v

Prashasti praises; land grant records a transaction; neither is transparent narrative.

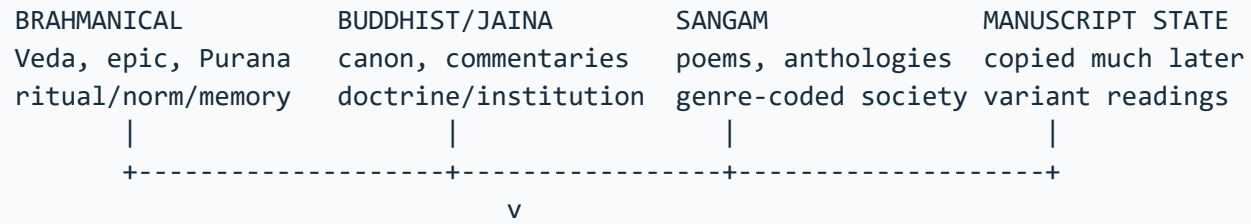
ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/12: Coins: object, text and economic instrument

COIN

- |-- metal, weight, fabric -> standard, mint practice, debasement
- |-- legend, script, title -> issuer and political idiom
- |-- iconography -> religious/royal representation
- |-- hoard/find context -> circulation, saving, frontier or crisis
- |-- overstrike/imitation -> succession, appropriation and contact
- |

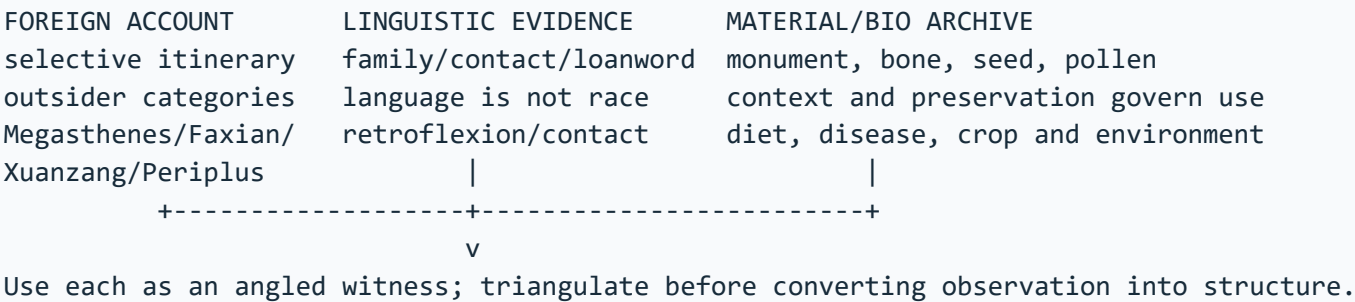
+> LIMIT: coin abundance is not a direct graph of total prosperity.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/12: Texts: genre, layer and transmission



Ask composition layer, redaction, audience and norm/practice gap before extracting fact.
Critical editions compare witnesses; they do not restore an uncontested original.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/12: Foreign, linguistic, visual and biological witnesses



ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/12: Triangulation and productive contradiction

QUESTION: urbanism / polity / trade / religion / social hierarchy

|

+-> text says X

+-> inscription records Y

+-> archaeology patterns Z

+-> scientific evidence dates the context

|

v

AGREEMENT strengthens; contradiction prompts genre, region and chronology checks.

VERDICT: independent convergence is stronger than repetition in one tradition.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/12: Source-based answer architecture: 10/15/20 marks

10 MARKS: identify source -> what it reveals -> named example -> one limitation

15 MARKS: classify sources -> compare powers -> triangulate a case -> qualify

20 MARKS: problem -> source matrix -> method/dating -> case clinics -> conflicts

-> silences/preservation -> reasoned verdict on confidence

EVIDENCE SENTENCE: X indicates Y because Z; however, genre/context limits W.

Never end with all sources are important; state which source answers which question.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/12: Evidence ladder and confidence control

EVIDENCE LADDER

1. = from source book = inference / standard knowledge = current affairs.
2. Source phase Approx date Marker
3. Ashokan epigraphy 3rd c. BC inscriptions become solid historical...

VERDICT: Source type controls the strength and limits of the historical claim.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/12: Examiner traps and contested boundaries

CLOSE DISTINCTIONS

1. Mains use: source-method support for the GS-I culture clause and for...
2. Contested issues Competing interpretations are attributed, evidenced...
3. Inscription and coin evidence: contemporary names, titles, claims and...

VERDICT: Qualification earns marks; false certainty is a hard failure.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/12: Integrated answer spine and qualified conclusion

ANSWER SPINE

1. Official UPSC papers: GS-I Mains 2018 and 2020; Prelims GS-I 2023,...
 2. Mains use: source-method support for the GS-I culture clause and for...
 3. B-13 Texts, coins, inscriptions and archaeology must be carefully...
- VERDICT: Claim, named evidence, analysis and qualification lead to a graded...